ATTENTION

Indistractable

How to Control Your Attention and Choose Your Life

Nir Eyal with Julie Li · 2019

Nir Eyal, who once wrote about building habit-forming products, turns to the other side: how to stop distraction from running your day, with a four-part model and dozens of practical tactics.[1,2,3,7]

WHY READ IT

- A fresh take: distraction starts inside us, not in our phones[3]
- Tactics for email, meetings, group chat and your phone[3,4]
- Chapters on raising indistractable kids and building focused workplaces[4]

GET THE BOOK

Indistractable by Nir Eyal with Julie Li
BenBella Books, 2019. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

A free guide inspired by *Indistractable* by Nir Eyal with Julie Li. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Distraction is an escape from discomfort

Eyal argues that most distraction is an attempt to escape an uncomfortable feeling such as boredom, loneliness or worry. Technology is only the proximate cause. Learn to handle the feeling, plan your time around your values, and the pull of distraction loses much of its power.[3,4]

THREE LESSONS

1. **Traction vs. distraction**
   Traction is any action that moves you toward what you intend; distraction moves you away. You can only call something a distraction if you know what you meant to do.[3]

2. **Ask of every trigger**
   Is this trigger serving me, or am I serving it? Keep the pings that lead to traction and remove the rest.[3,6]

3. **Willpower isn't a battery**
   Eyal reviews research suggesting that believing willpower runs out makes us give up sooner. Reimagine your temperament as well as the task.[4]

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THE FRAMEWORK

The Indistractable Model[3,4]

Eyal's four-part model, from the inside out.[3]

1 Master internal triggers

Deal with the discomfort

Notice the feeling that comes before distraction, and stay with it instead of escaping.[3]

Try: The 10-minute rule: wait ten minutes before giving in.[3,5]

2 Make time for traction

Plan your values into time

Timebox your week across three domains: You, Relationships and Work.[3]

Try: Schedule sync: agree your calendar with those who depend on it.[4,6]

3 Hack back external triggers

Pings, dings and interruptions

Tactics for email, group chat, meetings, your phone and your desktop.[3,4]

Try: No agenda, no meeting.[6]

4 Prevent distraction with pacts

Decide in advance

Effort pacts add friction, price pacts put money at stake, and identity pacts change how you see yourself.[3]

Try: Call yourself indistractable, and act like it.[3]

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

The Distraction Tracker

Eyal's log for finding your internal triggers.[3]

1. Keep a card or note open while you work.
2. Each time you get distracted, write the time and the feeling just before.
3. After three days, look for the most common feelings and triggers.
4. Choose one fix for the biggest one.

The timeboxed week

Eyal's way to turn values into a calendar.[3]

1. Start from a blank weekly template.
2. Add blocks for You, then Relationships, then Work.
3. Follow it for a week, then reflect and refine.
4. Share it with your manager or partner.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it this week

1. Run the Distraction Tracker for three days.
2. Try the 10-minute rule on the most common urge.
3. Turn off every notification that doesn't come from a person.
4. Timebox next week across You, Relationships and Work.

REFLECT

What feeling usually comes right before you get distracted?

Which trigger around you serves someone else's goals, not yours?

Try it in Sedi: Timebox your week in Timely's day view, including blocks for yourself and your people, not just work.

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READ THE BOOK

🎯 Indistractable

Nir Eyal with Julie Li · BenBella Books · 2019

This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Nir Eyal with Julie Li or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

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